

AQUILA THE EAGLE

THE PATTERN MADE BY THE STARS IN AQUILA CAN EASILY BE IMAGINED AS AN EAGLE SOARING IN THE SKY. AQUILA IS A SPECIAL EAGLE ASSOCIATED WITH THE GREEK GOD ZEUS.

One of the original 48 constellations, Aquila straddles the celestial equator in a rich region of the Milky Way. Aquila could be the eagle that carried Zeus's thunderbolts, or alternatively, it could be Zeus in the form of an eagle, which enabled him to carry Ganymede to Mount Olympus to serve the gods. The eagle appears to swoop down toward adjacent Aquarius, which is identified with Ganymede.

Aquila can best be found by spotting its brightest star, Altair (Alpha Aquilae), whose name is Arabic for flying eagle. It is the 12th-brightest star in the entire night sky and at only 17 light-years away, also one of the closest bright stars. With Deneb (in Cygnus) and Vega (in Lyra) it forms the Summer Triangle of northern skies. The supergiant Eta Aquilae is one of the brightest naked-eye Cepheid variables. Its magnitude changes from 3.5 to 4.4 in a 7.2 day cycle.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 22

Brightest stars Altair (α)
0.8, Tarazed (γ) 2.7

Genitive Aquilae

Abbreviation Aql

Highest in sky at 10pm
July–August

Fully visible 78°N–71°S

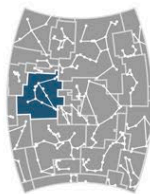


CHART 4

MAIN STARS

Altair Alpha (α) Aquilae
White main-sequence star

☼ 0.8 ↔ 17 light-years

Alshain Beta (β) Aquilae
Yellow subgiant

☼ 3.7 ↔ 45 light-years

Tarazed Gamma (γ) Aquilae
Orange giant

☼ 2.7 ↔ 395 light-years

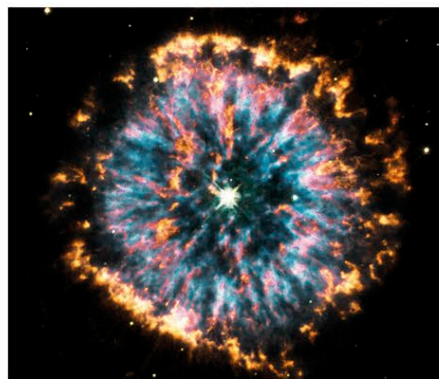
Zeta (ζ) Aquilae
White main-sequence star

☼ 3.0 ↔ 83 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 6709
Open star cluster

NGC 6751
Planetary nebula



Tarazed (γ Aquilae)
Aquila's second brightest star. An orange giant, which with Alshain flanks Altair to form a row of three bright stars

Altair (α Aquilae)
A main-sequence star almost twice the size of the Sun. It also has a higher temperature, which makes Altair appear white in color

Alshain (β Aquilae)
A yellow subgiant about three and a half times the size of the Sun. Preparing to become a more luminous giant

Aquarius

AQUILA

< NGC 6751

This planetary nebula, with a magnitude of 12.5, is about 6,500 light-years from Earth. At its center is a white dwarf of magnitude 15.5.